wanting to chat or to ask for an autograph. How could I? I asked enough United players to sign stuff for me when I was a boy. I don't like the idea of things turning up on memorabilia websites, people trying to get rich on the back of someone else's popularity but again, it's a balance. I'd rather risk making that mistake than risk disappointing a kid who's been standing, waiting, outside the stadium for an hour after a match. I know what it's like to look up to people, to admire the achievements of someone who's good at what they do. I know what it's like because I always have done myself. And still do.

I'm a fan. I always will be. I remember one night a few years ago, Dave Gardner and his girlfriend were down in London and Victoria and I took them to the Ivy restaurant for dinner. Dave got there first and he slaughtered me later about how the *maître d'* had changed his tone completely when Dave told him who he was supposed to be meeting. It went from: 'Who's this bloke?' to 'This way, Sir.' All in a split second. When we got there, the paparazzi were doing their stuff outside. Dave was starting to mock me for being a face at this expensive London restaurant when we looked across the room and saw Our Man at the same time.

'It's not him, is it?'

'I think it is, you know.'

'No, no, it can't be.'

It was, though: Michael Jordan, sitting in the corner, puffing on the biggest cigar I'd ever seen in my life.

'Look. Look who he's with.'

One of my all-time heroes was there at his table, chatting with Madonna, the pop star Ricky Martin and Tom Ford, who was head of Gucci at the time. I don't think Dave or I touched any of our food. We were sitting staring across at him.

'Should I go and get his autograph on a napkin?'

'No, you're not allowed to do that in the Ivy.'

Next thing we knew, a bottle of champagne arrived at our table. It was a little while after Brooklyn had been born and this was congratulations from Michael Jordan and Madonna.